

Executive Brief

Why federated enterprises fail at Agile scaling — and the operating-model-first approach that survives board scrutiny.

For executive sponsors, transformation boards, and BU leaders
Companion to Practitioner Playbook · Workshop Kit · SteerCo Pack
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Confidential working document · Not a framework certification guide

1. The problem in one paragraph

Most enterprise Agile programmes fail not because teams cannot run sprints, but because **no one designed how work flows across business units, countries, and shared services**. Training produces certified people. Rollouts produce ceremony. Boards see activity, not adoption. Regulatory work sits in parallel tracks. Dependencies stall above team level. The cost is not the coach — it is **Agile theatre at scale**.

WHAT LEADERSHIP TYPICALLY SEES AFTER 12 MONTHS

- High training spend, low enterprise adoption
- Inconsistent practices across BUs — weak audit evidence
- Compliance bypassing delivery flow — surprise at PI planning
- Sprint metrics green; portfolio bottlenecks unchanged
- Consultants leave; operating model was never institutionalised

2. The approach (operating model first)

Enterprise Agile is three things, in order:

1 Operating model Who decides, who enables, who delivers, how work flows across the federation. Sketched, scored, chosen with sponsors before rollout spend.	2 Enablement system CoE with written mandate, internal coach network, RTE/PO/leader paths — not training completion counts.	3 Rollout plan Pilot one real federated slice, expand in waves, embed governance in flow, measure adoption — institutionalise.
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Frameworks are tools. SAFe, Scrum, and Flight Levels are assigned to constraints after the operating model is chosen — not before.

3. Evidence this works (regulated federations)

Context	What was done	Outcome signal
Tier-1 European bank · multi-country programme	Enterprise delivery enablement across 50+ onshore-offshore organisation; liquidity reporting under regulatory scrutiny	Scaled delivery across BE, HU, CZ, BG, IN with federated handoffs and leadership-level enablement
Consulting firm · greenfield CoE	Built enterprise Agile CoE and enablement model from ground up with organisation-wide mandate	Repeatable coaching, governance, and rollout system — not project-by-project coaching
Pattern across 6+ global enterprises	Operating model design → pilot → wave rollout in banking and energy	Adoption measured at ART/cluster level; compliance embedded in backlog flow

4. Investment phasing (typical)

Phase	Duration	Investment focus	Leadership decision
Diagnose	Weeks 1–4	Federation map, pain points, success criteria	Agree what "success" means — flow, predictability, regulatory response
Operating model	Weeks 4–8	Half-day workshop; target model + fallback	Sign decision record before pilot spend
Enablement + pilot	Months 3–6	CoE stand-up; one federated slice; first PI	Approve pilot slice and sponsor time for PI events
Wave rollout	Months 6–18	Adjacent BUs, shared services, countries	Sequence waves by readiness and dependency — not politics alone
Institutionalise	Month 12+	Internal CoE ownership; refresh model annually	Exit external lead; fund internal enablement factory

5. What we ask of sponsorship

- **One decision before pilot:** operating model decision record (target + fallback, mandated vs. optional)
- **Protected sponsor time:** half-day workshop + quarterly SteerCo with explicit decisions, not status theatre
- **Honest regulatory capacity:** 20–35% PI reservation where needed — visible in backlog, not shadow tracks
- **Adoption metrics, not training metrics:** % in-scope ARTs operating to target model; impediment resolution; PI predictability

6. Risks if we skip this sequence

Start with SAFE training

Certified population, inconsistent practice, no federation design. Highest cost of change with lowest adoption.

Pilot without operating model

Local success that cannot replicate. Each BU reinvents scaling. Group reporting fails.

CoE without mandate

"Agile champions" with no authority. Coaches rotate; patterns do not stick.

Compliance parallel track

Regulatory surprises at PI. Audit gaps. Product capacity cannibalised invisibly.

7. 90-day executive view

Month	What leadership sees	Decision gate
1	Federation map, current-state pain points, aligned success criteria	Confirm diagnosis scope and sponsor coalition
2	Operating model sketches; workshop scheduled	Approve workshop attendees (BU + EA + portfolio + compliance)
3	Decision record signed; pilot slice named; CoE charter draft	Approve pilot and PI calendar alignment

ONE SENTENCE FOR THE BOARD

We are not buying Agile training — we are implementing a federated operating model with a pilot-proven rollout plan, adoption metrics, and regulatory capacity governed in flow.